

EYEWITNESS April 6, 1862

The **Hornet's Nest** at Shiloh

On the first day of the Battle of Shiloh, the Confederates launched a surprise attack that forced the Union army back toward the Tennessee River. In confused and ferocious fighting, General Benjamin Prentiss's men stood firm, defending a roadside position against repeated enemy charges—the noise of shrapnel and bullets buzzing through the trees gave the place its nickname of the Hornet's Nest. Although the Union troops surrendered after many hours, their resistance provided time for the Union forces to reorganize. The next day, Grant's reinforced army drove the Confederates back across the captured ground.

“Oh! The angry tempest that rolls around here! Belching cannons, shotted to the muzzle, are now plowing deep lanes in the Union ranks. How can we describe the sound of a storm of grape and canister, cutting their hellish paths through serried ranks of human beings. It is impossible ... the mighty armies are now struggling—struggling desperately for the life or death of a nation. Fiercer and fiercer rages the battle ... but fearful odds are against us ... the harsh, fierce barking of the dogs of war made the earth tremble, as if in the midst of a convulsion ... confusion reigns; brave men are falling like rain drops. All seems dark—seems that the Union army will be crushed by this wild sweep of treason ... the old Union banner seems to be drooping in the wrathful storm, but by an almost superhuman effort the tide is checked ... night comes ... the sable curtains have now fallen, closing to our eyes the terrible scene. Soon it commences to rain. Dark, dark night for the army of the Tennessee. Many brave men are sleeping silently. They have fought their last battle. Fearful, desolating war has done a desperate work ... the Seventh, tired and almost exhausted, drops down to the ground, unmindful of the falling rain, to rest themselves ... disastrous war has wrapped its winding sheet around the cold form of many a fond mother's boy, and before many days there will be weeping in the lonely cottage homes; weeping for the loved and lost who are